Is Grid Governance a Rationalisation of State Authority or Reconstitution of Patrimonial Dependence?
A Comparative Historical Analysis of Zhejiang Province

Liu Jiatong

I. Introduction

After the outbreak of COVID-19 in early 2020, China launched the largest public health emergency response since SARS. Although Xi Jinping is widely seen as a centralizer of power, the response of the party state system displayed a movement in the opposite direction. A large amount of authority and administrative resources were rapidly delegated downward to grassroots organizations, granting subdistrict offices and neighborhood committees unprecedented enforcement powers, as shown in Thornton 2023.

The core institutional vehicle of this delegation was grid governance. Zhejiang Province was among the earliest provinces to initiate a Level I public health emergency response. This highest level allowed the provincial government to directly impose quarantine, traffic control, and work suspension. In cities such as Hangzhou, Ningbo, and Zhoushan, urban communities were divided into thousands of grids. Each grid was staffed with designated grid workers responsible for screening incoming populations, tracing close contacts, distributing supplies, and enforcing quarantine rules. In Hangzhou alone, the municipal government launched the three color health code system within less than 48 hours. This system linked resident data collected by grid workers with Alipay location data, enabling highly precise monitoring of population movement, as noted by Thornton 2023.

Grid governance was not created by the pandemic. Its institutional origins can be traced back to pilot projects in 2004 in Dongcheng District and in 2007 in Zhoushan, as discussed by Mittelstaedt 2022. However, during the pandemic, the scope, technological capacity, and enforcement intensity of this system expanded

dramatically. Grassroots social control reached a level not seen since the Maoist era, as argued by Thornton 2023. At the same time, tensions became visible. Grid workers gained substantial discretionary power at the community level but lacked sufficient formal oversight. In some areas, residents experienced not only service provision but also intrusive control. This raises a broader theoretical question, asking that what form of state authority does grid governance represents?

This paper hence does not aim to judge whether the state has become stronger or weaker. Instead, it asks whether the form of authority itself has changed. Does grid governance represent a more rationalized and bureaucratic system, or does it reconstruct personalized dependency relations under a new institutional form. Drawing on Max Weber distinction between patrimonial authority and rational legal authority, using the danwei system of the Maoist era as a historical reference, and focusing on the case of Zhejiang, this paper advances the following hypothesis. Grid governance is neither pure rationalization nor simple patrimonial revival. It is a hybrid form. It bureaucratizes the infrastructure of control while continuously reproducing personalized dependency relations at the point of authority transmission.

2. Problematique

The theoretical understanding of grassroots authority in China has long been based on studies of the danwei system. Andrew Walder concept of neo traditionalism describes the danwei as a patrimonial authority system operating through institutionalized dependency. David Bray further shows how enclosed spatial arrangements physically reinforced this dependency. These studies provide powerful tools for analyzing state society relations from the Maoist period to the early reform era.

However, market reforms since the 1990s fundamentally transformed the institutional foundations of the danwei system. Housing commodification, labor marketisation, and increasing population mobility detached urban residents from their work units. The

reach of the state at the grassroots level weakened significantly. Grid governance emerged in this context as a new strategy to reestablish state control over a highly mobile urban population.

The question is whether the analytical framework derived from danwei studies can be directly applied to grid governance.

The answer is not straightforward. Patrimonial authority in the danwei system was based on economic monopoly. Housing, welfare, and consumer goods were fully controlled by the work unit, leaving residents with almost no exit options. In contrast, grid governance operates in a much more marketized society where residents have independent housing and employment choices. The material basis of dependency has largely disappeared. To simply classify grid governance as patrimonial would ignore these structural differences. Yet if it is described as a Weberian process of rationalization, given its standardized spatial divisions, digital platforms, and formalized performance evaluations, this also fails to explain a recurring empirical finding. Grid governance in practice continues to rely on personal networks.

Recent empirical studies highlight this tension from different angles. Tang 2020 shows how grid governance operates through the co-optation of community volunteers and retired elites, revealing a personalized mobilization mechanism behind formal institutions. Xu and He 2022, based on participant observation, demonstrate that grid governance deviates from its standardized design, with discretionary practices becoming the norm. Mittelstaedt 2022 argues that the grid system extends bureaucratic governance to the grassroots, yet service provision and social control become indistinguishable in practice. Thornton 2023 identifies a key paradox. Digital control expanded rapidly during COVID 19, yet its effectiveness depended on personal relations between grid workers and residents.

These studies provide rich empirical insights but lack a unified theoretical explanation. If grid governance is neither purely rationalized nor simply patrimonial,

a new analytical framework is needed to capture its hybrid nature. This is the gap this paper seeks to address.

3. Literature Review

After reading a rich number of literatures, scholars seemed have not reached a consensus on the institutional nature of grid governance. Existing research follows two broad and opposing approaches. One approach interprets the grid system as an extension of existing bureaucratic governance. Mittelstaedt (2022) shows that under pressures of institutional isomorphism, the grid system replicates top down administrative practices, making service provision and surveillance difficult to distinguish. Wu, Li, and Cao (2024) introduce the concept of party corporatism, arguing that the grid serves as a tool for political recentralization through party penetration at the community level. From this perspective, the core logic of the grid is administrative control rather than governance innovation.

The other approach emphasizes flexibility and multifunctionality. Meng, Wang, and Xin (2024) conceptualize the grid as a safety valve institution that enables agile governance through risk monitoring and community integration. Liu et al 2021 show that effective neighborhood collaboration depends on both social capital and state guidance, with the grid acting as a mediator between state and society.

These interpretations are supported by empirical evidence but leave an unresolved question. Is the grid a rigid bureaucratic tool or a flexible governance platform.

Recent micro level studies begin to address this debate. Tang 2020, based on fieldwork and interviews, shows that grid governance relies on personalized mobilization through community networks. Xu and He 2022 provide direct evidence that performance evaluation systems lead to data manipulation rather than standardized execution. Thornton (2023) demonstrates that digital control tools

depend on interpersonal relations to function effectively. Habich Sobiegalla and Plümmer (2023) analyze the case of Zhuji and show that the grid shifts between different modes of power depending on local judgement rather than fixed procedures.

At a broader level, Fulong Wu (2018) longitudinal study shows that the state did not retreat after the collapse of the danwei system. Instead, it returned through new professionalized forms of governance, which themselves created new dependencies.

These findings converge on one point. Bureaucratic infrastructure and personalised authority coexist in grid governance. However, existing theories cannot fully explain why this coexistence is structural rather than accidental. This paper introduces Weber framework to address this issue.

4. Theoretical Framework: Patrimonial Authority and the Danwei System

4.1 Weber Patrimonial Authority and Dependency

In Economy and Society, Max Weber distinguishes between different ideal types of legitimate domination. This paper focuses on rational legal authority and patrimonial authority.

Rational legal authority operates through impersonal rules. Power is attached to office rather than to individuals. Administrative actions are constrained by formal procedures and legal norms. Officials are accountable to the system instead of to personal superiors. This is the ideal type of the modern state.

Patrimonial authority is a variant of traditional domination. Its core mechanism is dependence. The ruler maintains power by controlling access to essential resources such as land, livelihood, and social status. Obedience does not arise from belief in abstract rules but from personal dependence on specific individuals. Resource allocation is discretionary. It is based on loyalty rather than universal standards. This

discretionary power transforms obedience into a personal relationship that must be maintained and negotiated, as discussed in Weber 1978.

Therefore, dependency is the defining feature of patrimonial authority. Without dependency, patrimonialism cannot exist. The key question is not whether a system uses traditional symbols, but whether it systematically creates personal dependence by controlling resources, and whether exit becomes difficult or costly.

Michael Mann provides an additional perspective. He distinguishes between infrastructural power and despotic power, as discussed in Mann 1984. Infrastructural power refers to the capacity of the state to penetrate society and implement decisions. Despotic power refers to the ability to act without negotiation. This distinction helps clarify the nature of grid governance. It clearly expands infrastructural power. The question is whether this power is transmitted through bureaucratic procedures or through personal dependency.

4.2 Dependency in the Danwei System & Principled Particularism

The danwei system of the Maoist era provides the clearest historical example of dependency. In Communist Neo Traditionalism, Andrew Walder describes the danwei as a multidimensional system of dependency. At the economic level, housing, healthcare, education, pensions, and even daily consumption were tied to the work unit. Material scarcity under the planned economy made this dependence binding. At the political level, personal files were controlled by the danwei. Political evaluations by supervisors could shape life chances for decades. At the social level, the danwei functioned both as workplace and living community. Social networks were confined within it. Exit meant losing economic security, political identity, and social relations simultaneously, as shown by Martin Whyte and William Parish.

Within this structure, Walder identifies a specific pattern of authority. He calls it principled particularism. Resource allocation appeared to follow ideological standards such as performance. However, these standards were vague and flexible in practice.

Local leaders had significant discretion. Workers demonstrated political loyalty in exchange for material benefits and career opportunities. This created reciprocal personal ties between subordinates and superiors. Walder describes this system as a clientelist bureaucracy. It was formally bureaucratic but substantively based on personal loyalty and exchange.

4.3 Spatial Closure and the Impossibility of Exit

The strength of dependency depends not only on resource control but also on the availability of exit options. Einar Bjorklund shows that the danwei limited exit through spatial organization. It was a physically enclosed compound. Factories, dormitories, schools, and clinics were located within the same bounded space. Daily life rarely required leaving this environment.

David Bray further argues that this spatial form was not accidental. It was a governance technology. Spatial enclosure created both a sense of community and conditions for surveillance. When all aspects of life occur within a bounded space, exit becomes extremely difficult both physically and socially.

4.4 The Institutional Construction from Danwei to Grid Management

From a Weberian perspective, the patrimonial nature of the danwei system is clear. Resource allocation depended on personal discretion. Obedience was based on multidimensional dependency. Spatial enclosure made exit nearly impossible.

However, Walder emphasizes a key point. This system was not a continuation of cultural tradition. It was produced by socialist institutional design. The planned economy created scarcity. State monopoly over resource allocation created the material basis of dependency. Patrimonial authority was institutionally constructed.

This insight is crucial for analyzing grid governance. If patrimonial authority in the danwei system was produced by institutional arrangements, then similar patterns in

new systems should also be examined at the level of institutional design rather than cultural continuity. The question becomes more precise. Under conditions where material dependency has largely disappeared, does grid governance reconstruct personal dependency through new institutional mechanisms.

5. The Feature and History of Grid Governance in Zhejiang province

5.1 The Institutional Lineage of Grid Governance

Grid governance did not emerge from nothing, and in fact it has a rich history in China. Benjamin Read traces the history of residents committees and shows that they have long functioned as key components of the state monitoring network. After the collapse of the danwei system, community construction and institutional restructuring became attempts by the state to re embed itself in grassroots society. Grid governance represents the latest stage in this trajectory.

Jean Christopher Mittelstaedt provides a systematic account of its origins. The system can be traced to two pilot projects. One in Dongcheng district in 2004 and one in Zhoushan in 2007. These two pilots represent distinct governance logics. The Dongcheng model focused on stability maintenance and public security. The Zhoushan model emphasized service provision and resource integration.

Th dual origin of Grid system is important, since t shows that grid governance has been a hybrid from the beginning, combining control and service as two coexisting logics.

5.2 The Evolution and Development of Grid Management in Zhejiang

Grid governance in Zhejiang developed in three stages. The first stage from 2007 to 2013 focused on service provision. The second stage from 2013 to 2019 expanded the grid into a comprehensive governance system after policy support at the national

level. In 2017, Zhejiang introduced an integrated governance framework combining digital platforms and grid management. The “Safety Zhejiang” application connected resident reports to central command centres where problem areas were monitored in real time, as discussed by Thornton 2023.

The third stage from 2020 onwards was driven by COVID 19. In Hangzhou (a city of Zhejiang province), the health code system was launched in a fast response to the outbreak of Covid -19. Zhejiang became one of the first provinces to integrate digital platforms with grid governance. Data collected by grid workers was fully connected to digital systems.

This trajectory shows clear trends of both bureaucratization and digitalization. Standardized spatial division, digital information platforms, and quantified performance systems all reflect rational legal authority. From a Weberian perspective, grid governance appears to represent rationalization.

5.3 Persistence of Personal Authority

However, a closer look at practice reveals a more complex picture. Tang (2020) shows that grid governance operates through co governance mechanisms that reproduce personal authority. It does not rely solely on anonymous bureaucratic execution. Instead, it systematically incorporates specific social groups. Middle class homeowners are recruited as volunteers. Retired urban elites are given key coordinating roles. Party organizations are embedded in residential communities.

The key point is that these actors maintain personal relationships with residents. They know household conditions, employment situations, and individual interests. Their effectiveness depends on informal social networks rather than formal information channels. Tang describes this as hybrid authoritarianism.

Xu and He (2022) provide further evidence. They show that grid governance functions through intelligence gathering, case coordination, and real time reporting.

However, in practice, the system deviates from its formal design. Grid workers face conflicting instructions from different levels of government. Performance pressure leads to data manipulation and task distortion. A system designed for standardization becomes dependent on personal judgement and social networks.

Thornton (2023) identifies a key paradox during COVID 19. Digital control expanded dramatically through health codes and surveillance systems. However, these tools depended on personalized relations to function effectively. Digital systems could not identify unreported returnees or detect illness within households. Grid workers filled these gaps through door to door checks and information gathered through social ties.

Habich Sobiegalla and Plümmer (2023) confirm this in their study of Zhuji (a city of Zhejiang province). They show that grid governance shifts between different modes of power depending on local judgement. These shifts rely on human intermediaries rather than fixed procedures.

The central hypothesis of this paper is that grid governance is neither pure rationalization nor a simple return to patrimonialism. It is a hybrid form. It bureaucratizes the infrastructure of control while continuously reproducing personalized dependency at the point of authority transmission. To test this hypothesis, it is necessary to identify two sets of features within the same institutional system. On the one hand, there are the characteristics of bureaucratic authority, including standardization, impersonality, and calculability. On the other hand, there are the characteristics of patrimonial authority, including personalised discretion, informal networks, and dependency relations.

This section takes Zhejiang Province as the main case. It evaluates the hypothesis by comparing bureaucratic indicators at the level of institutional design with the personalized features observed in actual authority transmission. Zhejiang provides an ideal analytical setting. Zhoushan, as one of the two national pilot sites in 2007, represents a service-oriented governance logic, in contrast to the stability oriented model in Dongcheng District. Zhejiang has since experienced a full institutional trajectory, from pilot experimentation to province wide implementation, and from routine governance to pandemic emergency response. The analysis draws on government documents and official media reports, as well as empirical findings from Tang 2020, Xu and He 2022, Thornton 2023, and Habich Sobiegalla and Plümmer 2023.

6. Case Study of Zhejiang Grid Governance

6.1 The Feature of Coexisting Bureaucratic Infrastructure and Personal Authority

At the level of institutional design, grid governance in Zhejiang clearly displays the core features of a bureaucratic system. It is based on standardized rules, impersonal procedures, and calculable administration. By 2022, the province had established 85,000 grids and 450,000 micro grids, forming a three-level structure of village or community, grid, and micro grid based on buildings. Each grid covers 300 to 500 households according to a uniform standard. This hierarchical spatial division follows consistent technical rules. Authority is transmitted through a formalized chain of command from top to bottom.

In terms of information management, Zhuji(a city of Zhejiang province) implemented a system that assigns a unique code to each dispute, enabling full process tracking. Jiaxing developed a digital platform that integrates multi source data to generate more than two million household profiles, producing precise mappings of house, household, and individual. In administrative integration, Putuo district of Zhoushan(a city of

Zhejiang) established a social governance centre that brings together 25 government departments and has handled more than 290,000 cases.

In terms of Michael Mann framework, these infrastructures significantly expand the infrastructural power of the state. The capacity to penetrate society, collect information, and coordinate implementation reaches an unprecedented level of precision.

However, the same system systematically embeds reliance on personalized forces in its design of human resources. Zhejiang adopts a 1 plus 3 plus N model. Each grid includes one grid leader, one full time grid worker, one part time grid worker, one liaison cadre, and N additional actors such as party members, volunteers, and building leaders. Only the grid leader and the full-time worker have formal status. In Hangzhou Yu hang district, 1468 grids are staffed by 1581 full time workers and more than 30,000 part time workers. The ratio between formal and informal personnel is approximately one to nineteen.

This means that most daily operations rely on non-bureaucratic actors. More importantly, the selection logic emphasizes familiarity rather than professional qualifications. Official documents repeatedly stress that grid workers should know the people, know the place, and know the situation. Across China, grid governance recruits large numbers of retired cadres, party members, teachers, soldiers, and model workers. These actors rely on personal authority and community familiarity to conduct mediation and information collection.

In Zhoushan maritime grids, grid leaders are often ship captains. In Putuo, dispute resolution depends on personalized mediation platforms such as the Lao Pan Studio, named after a retired cadre and operating on personal credibility rather than formal authority. This human resource structure is not an accidental flaw. It is a deliberate institutional choice. While building bureaucratic infrastructure, the state preserves personalized intermediaries at the endpoint of authority transmission.

Performance evaluation further confirms this pattern. In theory, performance metrics are the core mechanism of bureaucratic standardization. In practice, they generate personalized bargaining between grassroots actors and higher-level authorities. A 2019 analysis acknowledges three distortions. Grid workers engage in empty patrols by taking photos to meet quotas. Routine events are repeatedly processed to satisfy documentation requirements. Difficult cases are filtered out, with tacit agreement between lower and higher levels.

Xu and He (2022) show that in one street, 92 percent of 15,112 reported cases were trivial issues created by grid workers to meet quotas, while collective incidents were systematically concealed. Selective reporting and strategic coordination replace rule based standardization. This is a clear case where personalized discretion substitutes for procedural constraint in Weber terms.

6.2 The Expansion of Power and Exposure of Structural Complementarity During Covid-19

COVID 19 provided an extreme stress test for grid governance. As noted earlier, grassroots social control reached the strictest level since the Maoist era, as shown in Thornton 2023. The Zhejiang case confirms the structural complementarity between bureaucratic infrastructure and personal authority, while also exposing the rapid expansion of discretion in the absence of institutional constraints.

At the infrastructural level, Zhejiang response demonstrates strong technological capacity. In Hangzhou, the 3-color health code system was launched within 48 hours, making it the first city in China to adopt such a system. Across the province, 330,000 grid workers were mobilized, reporting more than 190,000 pandemic related events and analyzing more than 400,000 data points. These figures show that bureaucratic infrastructure enables rapid deployment and large-scale data collection.

However, the effectiveness of this digital system depends on personalized relations. Thornton 2023 shows that health codes cannot identify unreported returnees or detect

illness within households. Grid workers fill these gaps through door-to-door checks and informal information networks. In Wenzhou, grassroots cadres, party members, grid workers, and volunteers formed 24-hour monitoring teams. This mixed mobilization mirrors the 1 plus 3 plus N structure observed in routine governance.

At the same time, the pandemic reveals another dimension of this hybrid structure. When bureaucratic infrastructure provides powerful technological tools, and personalized discretion lacks institutional constraints, the expansion of power becomes almost inevitable. Grid workers gained the authority to decide who could enter or leave communities and who must quarantine. For many residents, this was experienced not as service provision but as intrusive control.

In Hangzhou, there were attempts to expand the health code into a broader system of daily health scoring based on behavior such as exercise and alcohol consumption. This triggered major privacy concerns and was eventually halted. Thornton 2023 also documents cases where health codes were used as political tools to restrict unrelated activities

These developments reveal an important theoretical implication. When bureaucratic infrastructure amplifies personalized discretion, and when constraints on discretion remain weak, the hybrid form is not a stable equilibrium. It becomes a dynamic structure of continuous power expansion.

The Zhejiang case thus supports the hypothesis at two levels. Under routine conditions, bureaucratic infrastructure and personal authority are structurally complementary. The former provides technical capacity, while the latter provides flexibility in implementation. Under crisis conditions, this complementarity is intensified. It enables unprecedented levels of social control while also exposing the systemic risk of intrusive governance when discretion is unconstrained.

7. Conclusion

7.1 From Economic Monopoly to Information Asymmetry

The Zhejiang case shows that grid governance bureaucratizes its institutional infrastructure while reproducing personal dependency in authority transmission. This supports the hypothesis but raises a deeper question. If patrimonial authority in the danwei system was based on economic monopoly, what is the basis of dependency in grid governance under market conditions.

The answer lies in a transformation of the foundation of dependency. In the danwei era, dependency was hard. Workers relied on the danwei for housing and basic goods. Exit meant complete material loss. In the grid era, dependency is softer. It is based on information asymmetry and administrative convenience.

Grid workers hold detailed information about residents. In Jiaxing, millions of household profiles illustrate this asymmetry. Residents depend on grid workers for administrative procedures, access to services, and dispute resolution. Refusal to cooperate does not lead to material deprivation, but it increases everyday administrative costs.

The theoretical implication is that patrimonial authority does not require economic monopoly. When the state controls information and delegates administrative discretion to personal intermediaries, dependency can be institutionally constructed. Walder insight that patrimonial authority is produced by institutions rather than culture is confirmed again.

Furthermore, the Zhejiang case shows that this hybrid form is not transitional. The state does not simply fail to institutionalize governance. It deliberately preserves ambiguity. Formalization would limit discretion and weaken dependency. Maintaining discretion means maintaining power.

7.2 Limitations

This analysis has several limitations. First, Zhejiang is one of the most developed and digitally advanced provinces in China, hence its experience may not represent less developed regions. Second, this study relies on secondary sources. It identifies structural patterns but cannot capture micro level interactions. Future research based on fieldwork would provide deeper insights. Third, this paper focuses on authority and does not fully explore residents' responses. How individuals perceive and respond to this hybrid authority remains an important question.

7.3 Conclusion

By comparing the danwei system with grid governance in Zhejiang, this paper shows that state authority in China does not follow a linear path from traditional to modern forms. Grid governance introduces technological upgrades at the infrastructural level, including standardized spatial division, digital platforms, and quantified evaluation systems. At the same time, it reproduces core features of patrimonial authority, including personal discretion, dependency relations, and informal networks.

The Zhejiang case demonstrates that this hybrid is a structural governance strategy rather than a temporary condition. The state preserves personal intermediaries because they enable bureaucratic systems to function effectively at the grassroots level.

This finding has broader implications. The transformation of state authority in contemporary China is not a process of replacing patrimonialism with rationalization, but rather a process of combining new technologies with personalized governance logics. Grid governance is one example of this pattern, and it is unlikely to be the last.

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